

The World Through Your Child's Eyes

Birth - 6 years



There are many who hold,
as I do, that the most
important period of life
is not the age of university
studies, but the first one,
the period from birth
to the age of six.

For that is the time
when man's intelligence itself,
his greatest implement,
is being formed.

Maria Montessori



"Look at our baby; sleeping like an angel. The eyelids covering her beautiful eyes, the button nose, the tiny, pink mouth; looks so adorable when she yawns. And those small fists curled up, like she has a few tricks hidden in them. You know what amazes me, when I look at Akira sleeping? For someone so small and helpless, it's amazing how she manages to get whatever she wants; whenever she wants it!"

"That's so true, my dear. She has managed to make our world revolve around her, isn't it? I used to be such a sound sleeper and yet, now, I wake up a few seconds earlier even before she starts crying for her feed."

"Oh yes. She has you wrapped around her little finger. She's worked her magic on you in these few days. Even I couldn't do it in all these years!"

"Ha-ha. I am her favourite person now because she knows me from when she was inside me, I guess. And of course, I am her only source of food! But don't look so sad. Soon those tiny hands will reach out to you too."



Creating a new life is an overwhelming experience! An impermeable cloak of protective behaviour envelops every single notion and action surrounding this amazing life event. The mere mention of the word 'baby' conjures up images of absolute beauty and utter vulnerability.

Despite being a seemingly defenceless small person your baby has some exceptional *powers*. Nature equips babies with the basic kit for survival. You will be surprised to know that the tiny fertilised egg, right from inception, contains all the potential of the bundle of joy that is being formed. Just as a tiny seed holds all the potential of a mighty tree, your little one is also an 'evolution' waiting to occur. Needless to say, the responsibility of nurturing this precious bundle falls on you, the parents. Here's a tip-off! A blend of '*Nature*' and '*Nurture*' holds the mantra to prepared parenting. Sounds easy, right? However, before you fly away on the wings of this new-found knowledge, reflect on the fact that you are the keepers of those *powers*. Knowing how Nature prepares your baby to cope with the new environment, accepting the role of nurturing this miraculous creation will make the parenting journey a fulfilling, spiritual experience.

Consider this; at the time of birth, the baby's larynx or sound box is placed high in the throat above the oesophagus to avoid chances of the baby choking. Over 3 months, the larynx drops down creating space for it to move and make the sounds vital to human language. However, your new born can cry lustily and draw attention whenever she wants her care-givers to tend to her, be it for feeding, changing or simply for some cuddle time. Soon enough, your baby will be able to do more than just cry in order to get your attention. She will wave her arms at you, babble or even just smile. The smile will definitely enslave you to her whims and wishes and have you dancing to her tunes!

Just as how growing to love her parents is a natural process for your child, so is utilising the essential powers bestowed upon her by nature. This part of her

mind which drives the instinctive force of life is called the *Horme*, meaning impulse or impetus.

Your baby, with latent survival powers, is in transit from the internal physical gestation to an exogestation that will prepare her for the new realm she has come into. During gestation, within the womb of the mother, repeated fission of the single fertilised cell results in growth and eventually a baby is created in over 40 weeks. After completing her physical development to a great extent in the womb, she is now ready for '*psychical development*', bulking up on the raw materials from her environment in the form of sounds, smell, touch and feelings.

The Absorbent Mind - Your Baby's Mind is like a Sponge!

Between birth and six years your baby tugs at anything that is in her vicinity, and it's not just the physical objects around her. She draws in the love, the touch, the language and the culture with her senses, just like a sponge. In the beginning, her supine position and limited range of movement with hands and legs will allow her very little exposure to the environment, but she is eager and ready for more. She uses her hands and senses as the tools to feed her very special mind, called the *absorbent mind*. As the months pass, she will turn and crawl and she will gain access to many more things in the world around her, owing to her inner powers.

Just like the sponge, which does not differentiate between clean water and dirty water, neither does your baby's mind. The absorbent mind in the initial stages cannot differentiate between which experiences or impressions to take and which to negate.

This brings the parents into the limelight, so to say! Everything done or said by you is being absorbed by your baby. While this ensures that the good things like culture, family traditions, language, etc, are being automatically imbibed by your baby for use in the future, even your slip-ups and bad habits are being closely watched! Having dinner while watching television and gadget over use could be construed as acceptable if the parents are seen indulging in these practices. On the other hand, the positive side of this wonderful phase is that you can deliberately focus on certain rewarding activities like:

- **Reading books:** In a home where the parents read, the children will definitely take to reading.
- **Playing a sport:** If you are in the habit of playing any sport, make sure you continue playing in front of your baby, despite the extra demands on your time due to the baby's arrival.
- **Pursuing a hobby:** When children watch their parents paint, sing, dance or even knit, be aware, they are making a mental note!
- **Upkeeping culture and traditions:** Children grow up unconsciously absorbing the distinctive customs and the traditions that exist in the family; even how courtesy is practiced at home. For example, being respectful towards domestic help or towards the people who work and help us or helping the spouse with housework, is a lesson being learnt by your child from you.
- **Interpersonal skills:** Your child's social skills will depend on how you go about your social life. They learn the basics of being a social being from you. Likewise, the case with the use of gadgets, children imitate their first and strongest role models, you!

All the impressions made on the supple, accepting mind of the baby are stored as memories. This unconscious memory, called *Mneme*, is the permanent storehouse of all the impressions relating to environment, language, movement, culture and social behaviour. In the first three years, your child does not possess an intellect, but she is in possession of the immense absorbent mind, using which she develops the *Horme* and the *Mneme* built on the innumerable impressions that she imbibes. As she turns 3, she begins to consciously take in the impressions with focus and concentration owing to the budding intellect that is slowly being created within her. The *Horme* and *Mneme* are vast powers and volumes can be written about them. We shall talk about the *Horme* and *Mneme* a bit more in another chapter.



Sensitive Periods - Your Baby's Inner Timetable

A new born calf totters around a bit and pulls itself up on its legs almost as soon as it is born. If new born babies could talk as soon as they are born, they would tell us that they are following an *inner timetable*! There are time spans for certain 'robust urges' towards acquiring faculties which, when accomplished, turn into milestones in your baby's calendar. It works on the same principle used for cooking good pasta. When cooked *al dente*, it is considered the best consistency, but if it is undercooked, it is inedible and when cooked too much, it turns mushy. The *al dente* stage is the sensitive period, just right to absorb the right amount of liquid and cook to perfection. These sensitive periods ensure that the natural urges of the baby are converted into physical and intellectual accomplishments, when allowed to develop unhindered in the appropriate time period.



The life-cycle of a butterfly will help you understand better the sensitive periods that are evident in your baby's growing up years.

At each stage, the being traverses through ranges or sensitive periods which push it towards the next stage of its life. The eggs stay in the bubble to stay safe, away from the sun and other dangers. The larva experiences the sensitive period to move towards the sunlight. The caterpillar experiences the sensitive period to feed and fatten itself. The cocoon settles into the bubble to hibernate and grow into a butterfly. And finally, the butterfly emerges.

"One of nature's most resplendent miracles is indeed the power of the newly born, with no experience at all, to find their way about and protect themselves in the outer world, guided by partial and transitory instincts which show themselves as Sensitive Periods."

Maria Montessori, *The Secret of Childhood*

Between birth and six years the child experiences sensitive periods for different faculties, much like the caterpillar using the inexorable tendencies that help its metamorphosis into a colourful butterfly. During sensitive periods, babies reveal a voracious interest in language, order, movement, social behaviour, refinement of senses and even small objects. Each sensitive period takes the baby through an exciting phase, at the end of which the baby develops an essential mental faculty and eventually gets immersed in another sensitive period. The time period for each sensitivity is distinct, and could overlap. The important thing to remember is that if the sensitivity is not taken care of and if the urge is not fulfilled, then that particular faculty could go wanting, and under-developed. Just like how a deficiency affects the foetus' physical growth during pregnancy, lack of valuable inputs during the sensitive periods will have adverse effects on the extremely time bound impressions that are meant to take place.

Let's take a closer look at the different sensitive periods that take the baby on this roller coaster ride of learning and absorption.

Sensitive Period for Language

The sensitive period for language begins at birth and lasts until the age of five, then resumes from the age of seven to nine. From birth to the age of three, the baby absorbs almost everything she hears and senses. Everything finds a place in the baby's potent, compliant brain (*Mneme*), even multiple languages!



Neha recounts how her son's gluttony for words got her into a funny situation at the supermarket.

"When my son was 14 months old, I used to strap him into the car shaped trolley while I did the grocery shopping. And I would narrate just about everything I did to keep him from crying. He would point and I would name it. "This is spinach. And that is rice. Oh, that's a knife; we don't need that now." That kept him happy.

One day, I was at the supermarket and couldn't find the condiments section. I started talking to my son saying, "Mummy can't find the mustard." And then, I looked down at my cart and remembered my son was home with his dad! I had become so used to giving him names of everything in the supermarket that I didn't even realise that I had not brought him along that day. I couldn't help suppress my laughter when I realised what I had been doing all along and what the other people in the supermarket must have been thinking.



Whilst this is a story about the struggle of a new mum, the equally important aspect is the 14-month-old baby's avarice for words, that kept him occupied and asking for more. The sensitive period for language ensures that the baby progresses seamlessly from vowels to consonants to words to sentences to grammatically strung language, in that power-packed time period. Studies

conducted at the Center for Infant Studies, Stanford University, reveal how babies who were spoken to while changing, feeding and essentially right through their waking hours, demonstrated higher levels of language development when compared to babies who experienced lesser verbal interaction in their early days.

Prof Anne Fernald, a developmental psychologist at Stanford University, recommends, "You need to start talking to them (babies) from day one....Children cannot learn what they don't hear."



"Please don't silence me with the pacifier. I'm voicing my way through the new sounds and the new world around me."

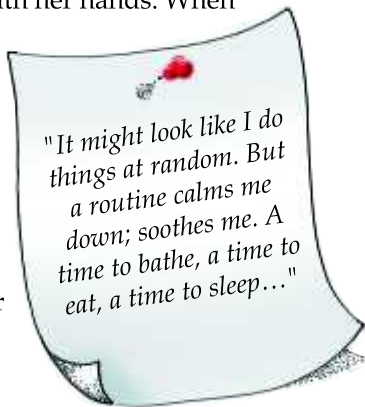
Sensitive Period for **Order**

Simply speaking, 'order' refers to a particular method or sequence of things. To your baby, it could be the way her bed is positioned, the time for her feed, or even where you hang your handbag and so forth. Sensitive period for order starts from birth and peaks at 18 months to 2.5 years and continues till the age of five. If change is inevitable, say when there has to be a change of residence, it is important for the relocation to be introduced gradually; allowing the child to come to terms with it. The ideal way of doing it would be to involve the child in carrying out the changes, if possible, by making her pack her toys and showing her where she would put them in the new house.

Preeti remembers with a shudder, how her two-year-old reacted to their first trip away from home.

"When my daughter was two years old my husband and I decided it was a good time to take her on her first holiday. We were shocked to see our adorable baby turn into an inconsolable one. When we flew back, we were received by my mother who convinced us that she would be perfectly fine once we get back to our own house. And when we walked into our house, our baby spotted her room and was back to being her angelic self; much to our relief! How a few missed naps and the different room décor made her so upset was a revelation for us."

If you slip into the baby's booties, the whole scenario would pan out differently! Your baby's world is a small one and each little detail makes a big difference to her. The mobile hanging over her play mat, for instance, is a huge incentive for her to kick her legs or reach for it with her hands. When that goes missing or is moved to a new place perhaps, her little cosy world alters in a big way for her. This would also explain why weaning the baby off the mother's breast or getting the baby used to a new routine is never too easy. It would be apt to conclude that *external* order leads to *internal* order. Order maintained around your baby would translate into a happy baby.



"It might look like I do things at random. But a routine calms me down; soothes me. A time to bathe, a time to eat, a time to sleep..."

Sensitive Period for **Movement**

Your baby is born with very little movement capabilities. As a newborn, she is required to concentrate all her energy on feeding and getting strong. Her mouth

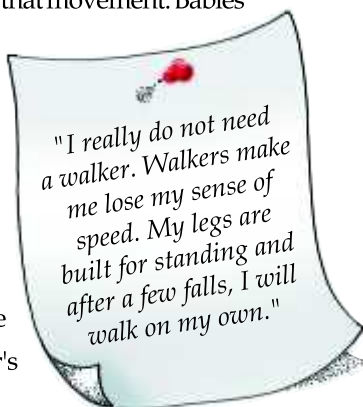


and hands and legs are the main tools of movement initially; mouth to suckle at the mother's breast and limbs to experience her first touch. Within a few weeks she will be able to see the person holding her clearly and try to grab them. Did you know that human babies are the only ones who have to learn and perfect their movements as they grow up? Human babies go through the entire sequence of rolling over, sitting, standing and walking in their first year; while animal babies usually acquire their whole range of movement within a few hours of their birth.

The sensitive period for movement begins at birth and lasts till the child turns five. From lying on their back and being quite helpless, they briskly acquire almost all the landmark achievements over the first year. It is quite

common to see children who have just started walking, break away from the person holding them or carrying them, whenever there is a chance to try their newly acquired skill. When we stop them from doing that, by picking them up or strapping them into a pram, we are really preventing them from improving that movement. Babies have an uncontrollable urge to learn new actions in this sensitive period for movement, and they should be allowed to freely acquire them. While running behind your baby all day long might seem like a marathon, it's sure to pay off.

The sensitive period for movement is a veritable hotbed of activity! But nothing can beat the first time the baby walks. Pradeep tells us about his daughter's first steps.



"Kaira was about 11 months old and had been standing, holding the sofa for almost a couple of weeks. But she would not venture beyond a single step. She was being extremely wary. We even tried tempting her by sitting across from her with her favourite toy and asking her to come and get it. But to no avail. While visiting the mall, we put her down on the floor in front of a mirror in a shop. Apparently, that was the motivation she needed to start walking. She walked up to her reflection and gave herself a huge smooch! And she didn't even stumble. It was perfect. I can never forget that moment."

Sensitive Period for Social Behaviour

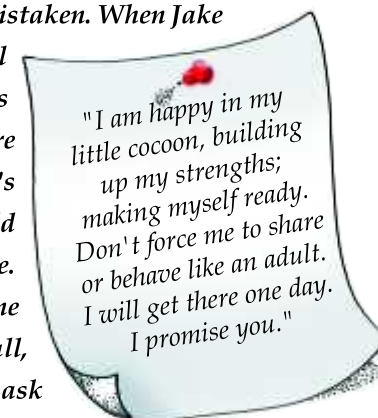
A baby is born as a person committed to taking care of herself; as an egocentric being. For a new-born, the sole focus is to feed and grow bigger and stronger. A few months later the focus shifts to acquiring language skills, movement skills and shaping her own little world where her comfort is paramount. It is only at around three years, that a child feels inclined to socialise and make friends. Just as the caterpillar conceals itself inside a cocoon and primes itself, until it is ready to fly out, a baby too prepares until ready to face the world and accept the rules of social behaviour.



If we pay heed to the fine print, so to speak, about a child's lack of interest in social interaction until the age of three, many a tantrum can be avoided. Imagine, yourself as a baby, with nascent language skills and limited movement capabilities. When multiple influences impinge upon your cosy world, before you are ready to accept them, your reaction cannot be pleasant. So, expecting your baby to share before she is ready will most certainly have distressing results. Even adults would not share their car with a complete stranger who comes up to them and asks to use it. For a baby who is yet to grow into a social being, such requests can be quite an ask.

Gina shares with us how she realised a huge truth about her little boy that made her experience as a parent, a lot simpler.

"Ryan had just turned one. We invited some friends over for dinner and presumed Ryan would be happy with the company. Our friends had an 18 month old baby, Jake. We were so mistaken. When Jake took Ryan's toy car from him, all hell broke loose. Trying to play the gracious hostess, I tried coaxing Ryan to share the toy with Jake. But Natalie, Jake's mum, gave me my first lesson in child behaviour which made absolute sense. She said, I might share my cell phone with a stranger who needs to make a call, but it would be utterly rude for them to ask for it or take it away from me while I'm in the



middle of a call! Jake is a stranger to Ryan and he's behaving perfectly normally, as you would too, to a complete stranger. He will share when he is ready to do so, when he feels the urge to do so."

Sensitive Period for **Refinement of Senses**

Senses are the tools provided by nature, for your child to build her intellect. Right after birth, senses help in establishing the first connection; with the mother. The mother's touch, smell and the sound of her heartbeat will be the only source of comfort to a new born baby. As the baby's blurry sight gets clearer, she starts recognising the people around her. Gradually, she will use her 'hands and senses' extensively to continuously imbibe knowledge about her new world. She becomes a 'sensorial explorer'.



Gurnani shares his experience about how his 15 month old son, Aryan, would point to a carrot and say 'orange'. "We used to wonder how that happened. And we used to joke about this confusion to our friends. When we went shopping, he would pick up a carrot and call it an orange. Aryan continued calling the carrot 'orange' for a while, much to our perplexity. It was when we visited a friend's house that the mystery unravelled. Our friends also had a son, Dhruv, who was about Aryan's age and they liked to play together. Aryan brought Dhruv's book about colours to show us. And in that book, the colour 'orange' was depicted with an 'orange coloured' carrot! That's how we solved the mystery. Eventually, he did figure out that oranges were orange too!"

When you hand a 15-month old baby a soft toy and say, "soft" baby will repeat it because you are saying it. But it is between 2 ½ to 4 ½ years of age that a baby actually understands that the teddy bear is soft to the touch unlike a hardback book. And as it happened in Aryan's case, the initial period of unbiased absorption of impressions transforms into sensorial absorption. Understanding and recollection soon follow. The large pile of impressions absorbed from birth to 2 ½ years will now be shelved in a focussed manner. The library of your baby's brain will start getting lines of neatly stacked impressions! These will form the building blocks of the baby's intellect. When the baby graduates from trying to grab the candle flame to puffing at the spoon of hot food to cooling it before putting it in the mouth, you know that the sensitive period for refinement of senses is at work.

Sensitive Period for **Small Objects**

Babies have a knack for finding the tiny piece of Cheerios that had rolled under

the furniture, or the bead that fell off your dress, and popping it in their mouth. This is a very significant event. I am sure you are wondering why something as inconsequential as picking small objects is described as a big event! This period of fascination with tiny objects and the



use of the thumb and pointer finger to pick things up is the start of the baby's fine motor movement development. And that is what makes it a significant milestone. This movement pattern, which is unique to human beings, will allow your little baby to achieve great feats in the future.

Contrary to popular belief, one-year old babies show interest in finer details rather than just responding to large impetuses. Till they turn one, babies are

mostly building on their gross motor movements like walking, running and jumping. It is between 12-20 months that they notice the finer aspects and go for it with gusto! In the short span of six months, babies develop a keen interest for small things that make up the big world around them. This interest is sustained as they are now able to crawl or walk towards the object and pay close attention to it. While adults are habituated to focussing on the big picture, babies will remind them to look at the little details all over again!

The sensitive period for small objects refines a child's hand-eye coordination, dexterity, development of the pincer grip (use of thumb and pointer finger), and fine motor movements. It is an important phase in child development and demands immense attentiveness from the parents; because whatever they can grab or pick up, they will take it to their mouth! While exploration is very important in this phase, safety and vigilance is paramount.

Jaya tells us about her little one's exploration of small objects that made her more vigilant.

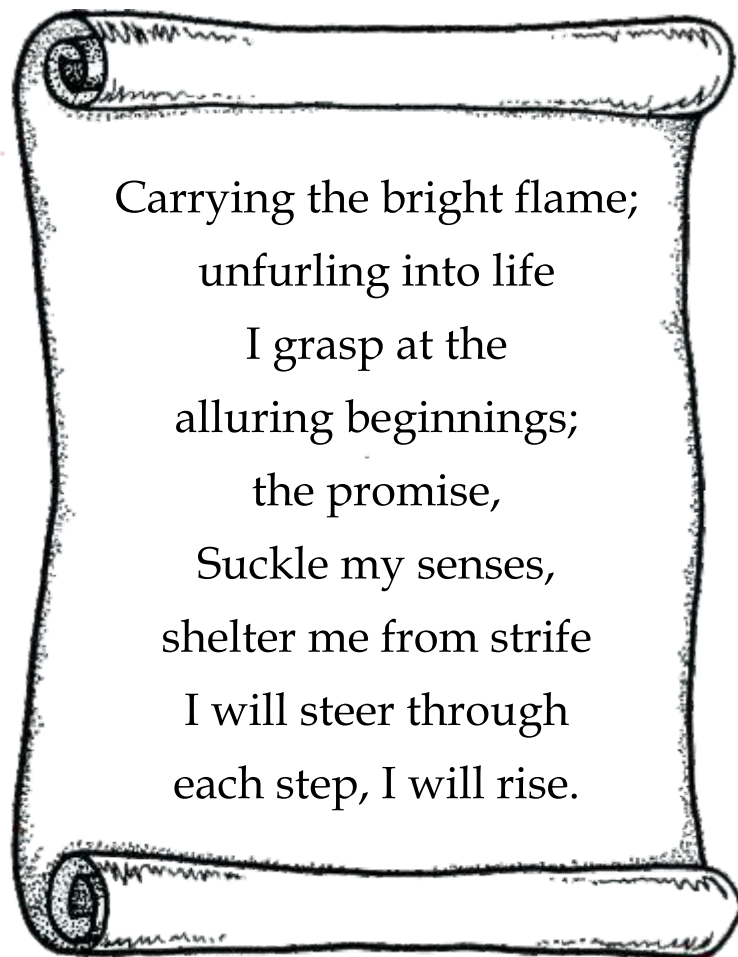


"I knew my little one was in the mouthing phase, putting everything she could grasp with her little fingers in her mouth; including her own toes. That was actually harmless compared to what she put in her mouth when she started crawling! I had left her on the floor and dashed to get my phone from the bedroom. When I came back I couldn't find her. I panicked and went down on all fours to look for her. I found her under the coffee table picking up a few weeks old shrivelled grape that my vacuum cleaner had missed! I have kept a sharp eye on her ever since."

Wild Boy of Aveyron

The story of the wild boy of Aveyron suggests what total disregard of the sensitive periods and the complete absence of human interaction could lead to. The feral

young boy was captured by hunters while he was foraging for food in the Caune forest in France. He had been living the life of an animal for many years; probably from when he was a little baby. Since he had had almost no human interaction, he had no language and behaved like an animal, with primal survival instincts. He showed disdain for extreme weather or unsafe situations and existed only to eat, sleep and avoid other human interaction. Despite many attempts to teach him to speak, it was unsuccessful. It can be assumed that since he did not have any exposure to spoken or written language during his sensitive period for language, he did not and could not acquire a language. The boy had been detached from the civil human tendencies cultivated through language, social interaction and sense of order, and ended up being more animal than human. Although the wild boy of Aveyron's story is an extreme case scenario, it throws light on the importance of the sensitive periods.



Carrying the bright flame;
unfurling into life
I grasp at the
alluring beginnings;
the promise,
Suckle my senses,
shelter me from strife
I will steer through
each step, I will rise.

Record Your Memories

- Have you noticed how your baby absorbs the sounds and sights around her? Can you rummage through your memories and jot down a few memorable ones? (*It will be lovely to read about it at a later date!*)
- What sensitive periods have you witnessed your little one go through? Which one was the most evident?
- Was there a particular happening that proved your child was going through the sensitive period for order? What was that?
- The sensitive period for small objects must have come across as a revelation for you! What was the weirdest thing your baby caught hold of during this period?
